China on the one hand and India and Japan on the other shows that the first condition does not hold at present, a fact that is exacerbated by doubts about the United States' ability and willingness to deliver on its commitments to Japan. The second condition depends crucially on China posing a joint or simultaneous threat to India and Japan. Otherwise, it is unlikely that either India or Japan will threaten the use of force to deter a Chinese threat to the other party. The third condition – a defensive alliance – is unlikely due to the commitment problems inherent in such an arrangement, which I have discussed elsewhere.[46] An alliance might signal resolve, but even this level of *de facto* or *de jure* mutual commitment between Japan and India is doubtful.

What, then, does the India–Japan relationship do for India? As mentioned previously, it provides a means by which to engage in long-term internal balancing against potential threats by building up the economic foundations of hard power and the ability to deploy it in coordination with other major powers. To this end, India singled out Japan as a major partner in Asia primarily because Japan sought Indian cooperation using effective economic diplomacy. In the process, India and Japan have created a degree of policy interdependence such that the cost of adjustment for India in the realm of investment and the cost of adjustment for Japan in the realm of diplomatic support might increase over time to the point where it is prohibitive for either side to deviate from the resulting equilibrium. Whether this situation will obtain or not depends on both countries' ability to build a sufficiently strong economic base for cooperation.

A strong economic base will enable the India–Japan relationship to flourish on its own bilateral terms rather than being nested within larger Asian and global rivalries and anxieties. The latter include the Sino–Japanese rivalry, the Sino–US rivalry, and the US–Japan alliance. Put simply, if